Hanging Out: Being Perceived as Friendly, Cooperative, and Approachable

Friendly people are those who are perceived to work well with other people. People like it when other people work well with them. Good players, folks who are perceived as cooperative, don't just play well during sports or other games; they also work well with other people at home, in the classroom during group project time, or even while waiting their turn at their desk. People who hang out well can stand in a group with others and not have the focus of attention be all about them all of the time.

When we're considered to be friendly or "approachable," the reward is that people enjoy spending time with us.

Here are some *ideas* for how to be considered *cooperative, approachable, friendly:*

1. **Move your body to go where the group goes.** Sometimes these are big movements like walking across the schoolyard; at other times, they're small movements, like just moving your shoulders to stay with the group.

2. **Think with your eyes.** Stay alert to watching what people are doing, what they might be feeling, and where they might be looking!

3. **Think about the people you're with.** What do they want from you? How do they feel when they're in the group? How should your body be turned when you're with them to encourage them to include you in the group?

4. **If it's a little boring for you but appears to be fun for the other person, you'll stay with the group...**because you know that when the group is doing or talking about something you think is cool, it might be a little boring for another person. Not everyone in the group enjoys all the same things all the time!

5. **No one knows it all!** Being part of a group means not telling people everything you know. People want to work or hang out with you—not just learn from you! Sometimes people actually get mad if someone else always tries to tell them things. That's because they feel like the person is acting like a "know-it-all." Being a "know-it-all" is not a good thing.

6. **All people keep learning to be cooperate, hang out, and be friendly across their lives!** Being "friendly" takes a lot of thinking, hanging out, and engaging in activities together to allow for practice to get it right! Keep trying to spend some time with other kids your age. This gives you some practice time to figure out how to think about what others think and feel. It also gives them a chance to see a really good side of you! Remember, everyone is learning social participation, not just you!

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